

Worksheet 2 · Skills S3.2 · Analysing non-fictional texts

Questions on the text — your scaffold

One routine for every factual text: in class, at home and in the exam. Fill in the gaps while we work on the Baxter text (book p. 230).

0 Know the task — the operator tells you what to do

Level	Typical operators	You ... / you don't ...
I Comprehension <i>What does the text say?</i>	describe, outline, sum up, state, point out	give the relevant content in your own words with line references · no stylistic analysis, no opinion
II Analysis <i>How does it say it — and why?</i>	analyse, examine, explain, compare, characterise	show how structure, language, style and tone <i>support the message</i> — with quotes · no retelling, no opinion
III Evaluation <i>What do you think — and why?</i>	comment, discuss, assess, evaluate	take a justified position, separate from the facts, with arguments and examples

1 Step 1 · Preparation

- a Read the questions first**, mark the operators.
- b Skim** the text: topic and main arguments.
- c Find out the purpose**: text type and its typical features (S3.1), source, author, date, target group.
- d Understand**: read again, mark key words, sum up each section in the margin (3–6 words).

Marking idea: number the sections ① ②; underline facts; wavy line under opinions; box stylistic devices.

Our example: Baxter, *Helsinki's huge VR gig* ...

Topic	<i>a virtual concert in Helsinki; future of VR tourism</i>
Text type	<i>feature article (online), with personal report</i>
Source, date	<i>The Guardian online, 2020 (Covid-19 lockdown)</i>
Target group	<i>general, travel-interested readers; not tech experts</i>
Purpose	<i>to inform about VR tourism and to entertain</i>

2 Step 2 · Writing

2a Start with an introductory sentence (first answer only)

In the [text type] "[title]", published in [source] in/on [date], [author] [reporting verb] [topic / main intention].

Baxter:

In her feature article "Helsinki's huge VR gig and the potential of virtual tourism", published in The Guardian online in 2020, Sarah Baxter reports on a virtual concert in Helsinki and explores what virtual tourism could mean for the future of travel.

2b Comprehension answers (I)

- answer *only* what is asked — in a logical order
- **own words**; quotes only for key terms
- line references: (cf. I. 5) / (cf. II. 16–18)
- present tense: *the author states* ...
- no stylistic devices, no opinion

Our extra rule:

Start each answer with a sentence that picks up the question.

Our model paragraph (Baxter: respect for Helsinki's achievements) — mark C, E, E:

(C) Baxter expresses respect for Helsinki's achievements through appreciative vocabulary. (E) Although she admits that the gig lacked "the buzz of being at a 'proper' concert" (II. 11–12), she stresses that "technically, it was impressive" (II. 12–13) and praises a "world of meticulously rendered make-believe" (II. 14–15). (E) Because she first concedes a weakness, her praise sounds balanced and credible, so readers are more likely to share her positive view of the city's innovation.

2c Analysis answers (II)

Thesis: answer the question in one sentence.

Body: one paragraph per aspect / section:

Claim what the author does	→	Evidence quote + line	→	Effect why? on the reader
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Conclusion: sum up how style supports the message.

2d Evaluation answers (III) take a clear position → arguments with examples (also from the text) → consider the other side → justified conclusion. Keep your opinion separate from the facts.

3 Step 3 · Editing and checking

Content

- ☐ I did exactly what the operator asks — no more, no less.
- ☐ Every statement is backed by a line reference.
- ☐ Quotes are marked “...” and exact; omissions as [...].
- ☐ I separate facts from my interpretation.
- ☐ My opinion appears only where asked (III).

Language

- ☐ present tense to describe the text
- ☐ no contractions (*does not*, not *doesn't*), no *I think* in I/II
- ☐ linking words show my line of thought
- ☐ precise verbs and adjectives instead of *says*, *good*, *bad*, *a lot*
- ☐ no repetition — I varied words and sentence starts

4 Useful phrases

Giving information on the text

The (article) was written by ... and published (online) in (source) on (date). · It deals with / provides insight into ...

Talking about the structure

In the first paragraph, the author presents ... · In the next section, the reader's attention is drawn to ... · The following paragraphs provide more details on / examples of ... · The author's line of argumentation starts off with ... and culminates in ...

Reporting verbs (instead of says)

states · claims · argues · points out · explains · emphasises · stresses · criticises · warns · suggests · concedes · admits · concludes

Talking about language and style

The author strictly separates / often mixes fact and opinion. · The repetition of ... / The use of words such as ... emphasises / underlines ... · The detailed description of ... evokes ... / makes the reader feel ...

Describing tone and register

neutral · matter-of-fact · objective / subjective · formal / informal / colloquial · enthusiastic · appreciative · sceptical · critical · ironic · humorous · emotive · alarming · urgent · optimistic

Summing up

All in all, the author gives an unbiased / a rather biased account of ... · The text presents the facts in a clear and objective / a very subjective way. · This enables the reader to draw their own conclusions.

5 Linking words and quoting

adding	furthermore, moreover, in addition, apart from that
contrast	however, nevertheless, in contrast, whereas, while
cause/effect	therefore, thus, consequently, as a result, since
example	for instance, to illustrate this, as shown by
order	first of all, subsequently, finally
concluding	all in all, to sum up, on the whole

- **Integrate** quotes into your sentence: Baxter calls the platform a “digital twin” (I. 16).
- **Line references:** (I. 5) · (II. 5–7) · (II. 5 f.) paraphrase: (cf. I. 5)
- **Omissions** [...]; **changes** in square brackets [].
- Never let a quote stand alone — always **explain** it.

6 Stylistic devices you meet in factual texts — and what they can do

Device	Typical effect	Device	Typical effect
personal anecdote, first person	makes the topic concrete and relatable	expert quotes, statistics	add authority and credibility
rhetorical question	involves the reader, guides the argument	contrast / antithesis	highlights differences, sharpens a point
enumeration, rule of three	stresses scope, sounds complete and memorable	repetition, anaphora	emphasises a key idea, creates rhythm
metaphor, comparison	makes abstract ideas vivid	hyperbole, emotive language	arouses feelings, creates urgency
direct address, inclusive we	creates closeness, shared responsibility	colloquial words	informal, light tone; reaches a wide audience
short sentence after long ones	creates emphasis, a punchline	irony	criticises indirectly, entertains

Name the device *and* its function in *this* text — a list of devices without effect earns little.

Online: the step-by-step course, fold-out tips and the writing coach for your own answers: edu-mrh.de → **Englisch** → **Klasse 13** → **Questions on the Text**